Remembrance: Vyacheslav Ivanov*

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Vyacheslav Vsevolodovich Ivanov was such a towering figure in the scholarship of our time that there would be no way, in the time available to me, to give some sense of his contributions, even if I had the skill and the knowledge to do so. To give you a sense of this, let me begin by quoting part of a memorial note that was written by my colleague Ronald Vroon, Chair of the UCLA Department of Slavic, East European and Eurasian Languages and Cultures; he wrote that Professor Ivanov "established himself as an authority in fields as diverse as Indo-European studies, Balto-Slavic linguistics, machine translation, psycholinguistics, cultural anthropology, mathematical linguistics, semiotics and literary studies." And yet Professor Vroon failed to mention "cinema studies"! This was yet another area to which Vyacheslav Ivanov was passionately devoted and to which he made signal contributions. So instead of a scholarly biography, or an enumeration of all the professional awards and accolades he received over the course of his long career, I'd like to share with you some more personal memories of my own acquaintance with this great man, and what he meant to us here in the Program in Indo-European Studies.

My first encounter with Vyacheslav Ivanov was not in person. As I've often told my students, it was my own teacher Calvert Watkins who used to tell *his* students that a sufficient reason to learn to read Russian was to be able to read the work of Vyacheslav Ivanov. Who cared about Chekhov and Dostoyevsky! No, it was the work of Vyacheslav Ivanov that was important—and one could see this all over Watkins's famous 1969 book on Indo-European verbal morphology, which we used to call (and some of us still call) "The Blue Book" (because of its cover): one need only flip through this book (which in the early '70s, when I began graduate school, I did a lot) in order to see plenty of references to the work of

* The following is a lightly edited version of remarks presented at the 29th Annual UCLA Indo-European Conference (Saturday, November 4th, 2017).

David M. Goldstein, Stephanie W. Jamison, and Brent Vine (eds.). 2018. *Proceedings of the 29th Annual UCLA Indo-European Conference*. Bremen: Hempen. 1–5.

Ivanov, such as his 1965 book, of course in Russian, with the title (in translation) *Indo-European, Proto-Slavic, and Anatolian Linguistic Systems: Comparative and Typological Studies*. I actually remember going to Widener Library just to have a look at this book (and this was before I learned any Russian): I knew of course about Indo-European scholarship in French and German, and I could even imagine that there was useful work on Indo-European published in other European languages, maybe Italian or Spanish; but could it really be true that there was important work in *Russian*? I found these books in the stacks, and sure enough, nestled among all the Cyrillic (which at that time would have been almost as indecipherable to me as pre-Ventris Linear B), there it was: the books were chock full not only of Greek and Latin and Germanic and Slavic forms, but *full of Hittite*! This was incredible. Not long after that, when Cal Watkins told me I should go to the Slavic Department and take their course on Old Church Slavic, the Slavic Department refused to allow it, unless I simultaneously took their course on intensive Russian. It was, of course, a stupid requirement for students of Indo-European; but I did it, and I've never regretted it. And yes, by now I've read much more Ivanov than Chekhov or Dostoyevsky.

It was still some years in the future before I was to meet Vyacheslav Ivanov in person. But before that time, I had learned enough Russian to be asked, by the journal *Language*, to write a review of his massive two-volume work, co-authored with the Georgian scholar Gamkrelidze and published in 1984, called *Indo-European and the Indo-Europeans*. This was the heyday of the glottalic theory, which was a big part of the phonological portion of the book; and I was not a fan. Little did I know, after writing my rather negative review, that about ten years later I would be applying for a job at UCLA, where Ivanov had already been teaching for several years. I assumed that the review would kill my chances; but no, I was hired—and when I finally met Vyacheslav for the first time, he couldn't have been more gracious. He clearly saw how nervous I was, and even mentioned the review, saying something like, "Actually, in that review you made some good points."

This was typical of his kindness. I'd like to share a reminiscence about Vyacheslav that was recently conveyed to me by a graduate of our program. He wrote to me in an email:

> As for Prof. Ivanov, I took quite a few of his classes, including one individual study class, in which we read a number of Hittite texts. Working with Prof. Ivanov one on one was very pleasant, and it was amazing how he never needed to consult the dictionary—even when he was dealing with non-Indo-European languages (like Akkadian!). Prof. Ivanov was always very kind to me …—I can-

> not forget one time we met, and even though he looked rather tired himself, he smiled to me, and asked: "everything good for you? …."

Reading Hittite one-on-one was something Vyacheslav never refused to do; and in fact, he never refused *any* teaching assignment we asked him to undertake. He taught everything: besides Hittite, he also taught Tocharian, Indo-European phonology and morphology, and our course on Indo-European mythology and poetics, which is a doctoral requirement for our students. As a matter of fact, he was scheduled to teach this course for us this coming winter quarter. We'll postpone it until next year, probably in a team-taught version—which is telling: it will take three or four of us to offer a course that he easily managed to teach single-handed. And there were *new* courses: with Robert Englund of Near Eastern Languages, he developed a successful course on writing systems; and long before "diversity" became a buzzword at UCLA (and long before the "diversity requirement" and "diversity courses"), he devised a course he was passionate about, called "Languages of Los Angeles"—a way of showcasing probably the most linguistically diverse part of the country, where (according to Vyacheslav) about 200 languages are represented in the area.

I regret that one type of teaching he did for us will never be repeated, as it cannot be replicated by any of us: this involved his contribution to our team-taught "proseminar" course. This is a sort of professional training course that's required for our first- and second-year students; and we used to include some coverage of the history of Indo-European studies. Vyacheslav brought in photocopies of selections to read from the earliest work of Franz Bopp, which suddenly, as we listened to him speaking about these old texts, seemed fascinating, and he then went on to convey the excitement of the neogrammarian period. It always seemed that Vyacheslav personally knew everyone worth knowing, and one had the feeling that any moment he might say something like, "You know, when I was having coffee one day with Karl Verner, …." And he had this habit of introducing topics by saying, "You know, …"—which was a sort of kindness to his interlocutor or to the class, since in fact, nine times out of ten, we *didn't* know; and instead it was a signal that if we listened carefully, we were about to learn something interesting.

He was also, despite his immense gifts, a man of great modesty. True, he published more than a dozen books and something like 1,000 articles. Yet more than once, I heard him joke self-deprecatingly about his scholarly output by talking about what he called his "graphomania."

One type of output that I suspect is less well known to Indo-Europeanists is his poetry. He was an accomplished poet and a first-rate scholar of Russian literature, well-known for his work on the great Russian poet and prose author Boris Pasternak. Vyacheslav, like many Russians, admired Pasternak's translations of Shakespeare. So I'd like to close with two lines from *Hamlet*, when Hamlet speaks about his father:

On čelovek byl v polnym smysle slova.
Už mne takovo bol'še ne vidat'.

He was a man. Take him for all in all.
I shall not look upon his like again.

H. CRAIG MELCHERT

My recollections of Vyacheslev Vsevolodovich Ivanov inevitably combine the personal and professional. I had previously met Vyacheslav briefly several times at conferences, but only came to know him well after I joined the UCLA Program in Indo-European Studies in 2007. Like Brent Vine's review of the Russian original, my own of the English translation of Gamkrelidze and Ivanov's *Indo-European and the Indo-Europeans* was decidedly mixed, and Vyacheslav and I had also crossed swords over several issues involving the Indo-European Anatolian languages. I could not imagine that I would have been his first choice as the new Diebold Chair. But he could not have been more gracious in welcoming me to PIES and UCLA. Furthermore, while expressing the preference—after many years of heavy teaching for both PIES and Slavic Languages—to focus his teaching in Slavic, he also stressed that he was prepared to continue to teach for PIES whatever I and colleagues felt was needed by the students. As Brent has indicated, Vyacheslav continued, in the event, to offer regularly the required course in Indo-European myth and poetics that no one could teach as he could and was willing to offer upon student request a seminar in any language or topic that was not covered in our regular courses. He also continued to serve on dissertation committees and took an active part in program governance, the annual fall conference, block seminars, and visiting lectures. As program chair, I was and remain immensely grateful to him for his unusual flexibility and for all his contributions to the continued vitality of PIES.

Given my own area of specialization, I naturally tend to recall Vyacheslav's scholarship with Hittite implications. Brent has called attention to Calvert Watkins' great respect for Vyacheslav and Cal's admonition that all of us students